

[The impartial spectator] calls to us, with a voice capable of astonishing the most presumptuous of our passions, that we are but one of the multitude, in no respect better than any other in it; and that when we prefer ourselves so shamefully and so blindly to others, we become the proper objects of resentment, abhorrence, and execration. It is from him only that we learn the real littleness of ourselves. It is this impartial spectator . . . who shows us the propriety of generosity and the deformity of injustice; the propriety of reining the greatest interests of our own, for the yet greater interests of others . . . in order to obtain the greatest benefit to ourselves. It is not the love of our neighbour, it is not the love of mankind, which upon many occasions prompts us to the practice of those divine virtues. It is a stronger love, a more powerful affection, the love of what is honourable and noble, the grandeur, and dignity, and superiority of our own characters.

Smith's magnificent cadences can hardly help but inspire us citizens of this twenty-first century with the very values that we are ignoring and in danger of completely losing. The impartial spectator is one of the central metaphors that define those values, the high values of the eighteenth century.

“The Moral History of U.S. Business”

The evidence suggests that the values held high by Franklin and Smith were not uncommon among the businessmen of that era. Indeed, it seems almost providential that the very same 1949 issue of *Fortune* that inspired my Princeton University thesis included a feature essay entitled “The Moral History of U.S. Business.” Although I had no clear recollection of the contents of the essay when I reread it a few years ago, I'm certain that I read it at the time. Still, I quickly found myself reflecting on Vanguard's founding principles, which seem to me to be related to the kind of moral responsibility of business that was expressed in that ancient *Fortune* essay.